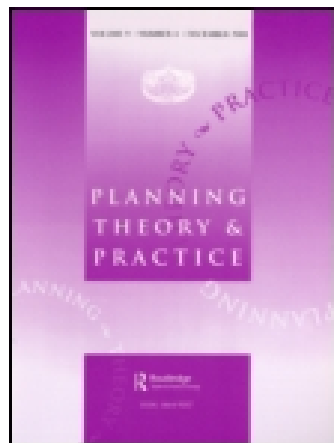




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In Search of the “Strategic” in Spatial Strategy Making¹

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ABSTRACT *In recent years, city governments and other entities concerned with urban futures have been exhorted to produce spatial strategies, indicating how their areas might develop in the future. But many of the resultant strategies do little “strategic work” in the sense of shaping future development trajectories. This paper reviews the meaning of “strategic work” in terms of mobilising attention to an urban area as a whole, and influencing the way that multiple actors involved in urban development shape their interventions. It emphasises the key judgements which those involved in promoting such strategic work have to make and discusses how the capacity for making such judgements may be cultivated among individuals, groups, and the wider political community involved in urban governance.*

Keywords: Spatial planning; practical judgement; strategy making; public realm; planning theory

Spatial Strategy Making in Complex Urban Contexts

During the 1990s and 2000s, there has been a wave of energetic effort in producing spatial strategies for city regions and metropolitan areas. This effort has been particularly evident in Europe,² but is also to be found in the USA (Wheeler, 2002), and in other parts of the world. Making such strategies, often equated with the production of some kind of document and visualisation, has been an important area of planning activity throughout the twentieth century (Ward, 2002). Advocates of strategy making stress its ability to locate specific interventions aimed at improving urban environments in a wider context, and its capacity to enhance the identity of an urban area. Their concerns include achieving greater national and international visibility for their locales; co-ordinating project initiatives; connecting interventions in different parts of an urban area, often in different jurisdictions; linking development locations to major infrastructure investments, thereby reducing spatial injustices; promoting economic opportunities; limiting threats to environmental balances; and working out which aspects of the past to conserve.

All kinds of planning instruments have evolved to give regulatory and political strength to such spatial strategies. It is often assumed that these instruments, for example, general regulatory plans (as in southern Europe and parts of Latin America), structure plans (as in north-west Europe), spatial development strategies (as promoted in the *European Spatial Development Perspective* (CSD, 1999)), schema directeur (in France), and comprehensive plans (USA), are effective carriers of such strategies. Funding bodies, such as the EU, the

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international aid agencies, and many higher tier government funding programmes, have also encouraged the production of strategies and visions. Ideas promoted in the field of public management have been used by funders partly to control how their funds are used, but also to encourage the setting of project proposals by applicants in the context of wider programmes of intervention, so funders can assess the “value-added” of their aid contribution (Ferlie *et al.* 1996). One consequence has been that a lot of “strategies” have been produced by agencies involved in urban governance and urban development. However, only some of these actually produce significant effects other than ensuring formal compliance in order to attract funds or meet regulatory requirements. Some strategy statements may serve political purposes through a rhetorical flourish which displays the promises of a mayor or local regime. Other so-called strategies may merely record already well-established directions.

Only some of these strategies are “strategic” in the sense understood by Albrechts:

Strategic planning is selective and oriented to issues that really matter. As it is impossible to do everything that needs to be done, “strategic” implies that some decisions and actions are considered more important than others and that much of the process lies in making the tough decisions about what is most important for the purpose of producing fair, structural responses to problems, challenges, aspirations, and diversity. (Albrechts, 2004, pp. 751–752)

Here, Albrechts is referring both to a general quality of planning work and to planning activity focused on a broad phenomenon such as a city region or larger territory. As Kitchen (2007) argues, all planning work has a strategic dimension in the sense that a wide range of considerations are “integrated” into the judgements made about any specific intervention. What distinguishes the spatial strategy-making referred to here is the concern to shape the dynamics through which larger urban regions evolve. In such situations, the intellectual challenge is to imagine the “entity” in question (what and where is our “city”, see Healey, 2004a; Vigar *et al.*, 2005), its connectivities and the relation between its parts (people and groups, places and neighbourhoods) and the “whole” (the city, or urban region understood as an entity), and the relations with wider systems which flow through such an area. Such strategic initiatives also have to face the political challenge of mobilising attention to, and creating a “public” around, such an entity (Gualini, 2004; Healey, 2007).

How then, as analysts, can we distinguish efforts in spatial strategy making focused on large urban areas which are “strategic” in their intentions and in their actual and potential consequences? As practitioners, how can we tell when and how to do such “strategic” work and how can we learn how to do it? In this paper, I define “strategic work” in the planning field as both integrative and as geared to efforts to change direction, to open up new possibilities and potentials, and to move away from previous positions. Much planning work involves maintaining, managing and conserving local environments, within relatively stable parameters. Spatial strategy making, as understood by Albrechts, is explicitly transformative governance work. It is aimed at responding to changing contextual parameters and at making a contribution to those parameters, as an enduring piece of public infrastructure, in the manner of famous plans such as Patrick Abercrombie’s plan for Greater London (1944) and Daniel Burnham’s Chicago Plan of 1909 (Ward, 2002). It is in this sense that spatial strategies have a “structuring” dimension.

In this paper, I focus in particular on the critical judgements that those involved in such transformative strategy making face, and on the practical “art” of making such judgements (Vickers, 1965). These judgements involve technical expertise and

political astuteness. They combine analytical knowledge and moral considerations. They demand a broad grasp, a sensitivity to a plurality of issues and concerns, and an awareness of the detail of experience and of what it takes for a strategic idea to shape the flow of ongoing activity. Making spatial strategies that get to matter is not an easy assignment. Such strategies, although sometimes associated with a key politician (as with Mayor Maragall in Barcelona in the late twentieth century (Marshall, 2004)) or a planner (such as Abercrombie and Burnham, cited above),³ are rarely the product of the effort of a single individual. They arise from a collective governance effort and they "work", in terms of having effects, because they become embedded in the governance culture of a locality.

This paper, then, is a review essay. It is partly an analysis of what is involved in making the judgements involved in spatial strategy making that "gets to matter". It is also an exercise in "normative abstraction", culling from my own research, reading and experience what seem to me to be critical dimensions of the "art of judgement" relevant to the activity of making spatial strategies.⁴ I attempt a kind of bridge between the theorists of socio-spatial change and the work of acting to generate change, to transform place qualities and connectivities, in ways which might have the potential to encourage future benefits to emerge. Before embarking on the review itself, I expand below on the activity of spatial strategy making in the planning field.

Spatial Strategy Making as an Area of Planning Activity

Along with Albrechts (2004), I understand spatial strategies for large urban complexes as social products which emerge as an important part of the governance "infrastructure" of an area. By this I mean that they do "work" by helping to frame and focus the way people involved in urban development processes and projects come to think and act. By "governance", I mean the array of activities and agencies involved in collective action in an urban area (Cars *et al.*, 2002; Le Galès, 2002).⁵ Spatial strategies get to "work" by providing an orientation, or reference frame, which gets shared by many stakeholders in urban development processes.⁶ This orientation may be expressed in general principles or in spatial images such as maps and diagrams. Spatial strategies which get to have transformative effects accumulate the power to frame discourses and shape action through their resonance with issues and problems which are causing concern within a political community, or "polity",⁷ and through the persuasive power of their core arguments and metaphors. If sufficient power is accumulated to give momentum to these strategic orientations, then the framing ideas may travel across significant institutional sites of urban and regional governance, to enrol others with the power to invent, invest and regulate subsequent development. In this way, strategic orientations may come to endure through time and have consequences in shaping future qualities and potentialities.⁸

Yet spatial strategy making is no simple activity which can be managed by procedural formulae. It is "a messy, back-and-forth process, with multiple layers of contestation and struggle" (Healey, 2007, p. 182). This "back and forth" process provides a good illustration of what policy analyst John Kingdon (2003) means when he refers to streams of policy "problems" and "solutions" jostling together, with clear "policies" emerging when a solution and a problem become attached. In the diffused governance landscapes which have emerged in western Europe in recent years, and which are common in metropolitan areas where urban relations stretch across administrative jurisdictions in complex ways,⁹ spatial strategy making may involve something more than selecting what are the "critical" problems and identifying good ways of addressing them. It may also involve searching out and creating a political community which identifies with the urban complex in question.¹⁰

Strategies that make a difference, then, inherently transform, though such changes may emerge slowly over time and in unpredictable ways.¹¹ Strategies encourage a momentum towards some directions rather than others. In the public sphere, they are thus political acts, challenging established power dynamics and mobilising energy to move in different directions, although there are all kinds of ways in which such strategies are grounded in formal political jurisdictions. Because such strategies are social products formed to do governance work, they raise difficult political questions about their legitimacy and accountability. For those with expertise in their field, the associated technical knowledge and values draw them into the political struggle over ideas and directions. These values are not merely about making sure that some consideration is given to critical connections and relations in and beyond an urban area, that is to a systematic consideration of connectivities and the relations between “parts” and “wholes” (Churchman, 1979). Rather, planning expertise is also associated with a concern for social and environmental well being, or “flourishing” (Friedmann, 2002, 2008). Where experts and others committed to this project become involved in spatial strategy making, they will be faced not only with the pressure to keep an open, “comprehensive” orientation to complex interrelations which co-exist in the urban area in question (Hoch, 2007). They will also have a specific moral position about why certain strategic directions should be encouraged and others closed off. They become advocates of particular kinds of opportunity for future generations. They may add to the “stream” of problems and solutions in search of one another, and to what I have earlier called the “argumentative jumble” which has to be sorted through by those wishing to affect the type of spatial strategy making that has the potential to make a difference (Healey, 2006). Spatial strategy-making efforts thus have the potential to make a difference beyond framing the way many parties think about the future development of an urban complex. Such efforts also contribute to enlarging public debate about urban futures.

What, then, does “doing” such transformative strategic work involve? Drawing on my earlier work on the nature of strategic spatial planning (Healey, 2007), I emphasise four interacting dimensions (see Figure 1). The first centres on whether, why and how to mobilise attention to an urban complex, understood as a whole in some way. The second emphasises what is at stake, for whom and where, in the socio-spatial complex of an urban area, and how the power to act in relation to these stakes is or could be distributed. The third concerns the mobilisation and enrichment of the knowledge resources available to strategy-making work, and the fourth centres on how strategic ideas are created, as key framing concepts and projects with the power to shape future directions and actions.

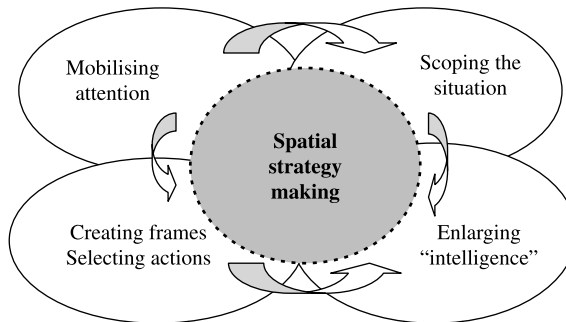


Figure 1. Dimensions of spatial strategy making.

The Momentum for Spatial Strategy-Making Initiatives

Despite the elision in popular perceptions between planning work and the widespread presence of city plans, transformative spatial strategies in the sense outlined here are not necessarily appropriate for every urban area. The making of a city plan may merely consolidate well-established ideas and practices as a basis for exercising formal legal powers, such as those enabling site assembly and land-use regulation. Any wider strategy may be left as implicit, or carried in the flow of decisions about small-scale changes, or emerge from the way in which larger place transformation projects are designed and developed. Explicit strategy-making work that is more than procedural compliance and political rhetoric emerges in place development and management work when some parties become frustrated by established ideas, regulatory practices and the design and decision making around major projects. For example, rising concerns about noise and air pollution around large airports may force changes in spatial strategies. In the Amsterdam area, locations designated for development near Schiphol international airport had to be re-designated as open areas when regulations governing noise pollution were tightened (Healey, 2007). Or some particular interests may become frustrated about the lack of attention to the significance of a major emerging challenge, such as addressing the multiple implications of climate change prognoses or re-configuring transport infrastructures. Salet and Thornley (2007) argue that the momentum for spatial strategy making in metropolitan areas has been driven in western European cities especially by urban and regional transport agencies. Alternatively, they may result from a sense of fragmented and overlapping initiatives, which, instead of producing creative synergies, undermine each other in a destructive manner.¹²

A key area of judgment relates, then, to an assessment of the institutional moment, or “opportunity structure” (Tarrow, 1994), for spatial strategy making. This leads spatial strategy makers to consider such questions as: what is the momentum for an explicit spatial strategy-making initiative? What forces and actors are driving this? What is the scope for the transformation of discourses and practices through such an initiative? How strong is the momentum? Can it be strengthened and what might weaken it? What kind of process is already underway, what might evolve and what could be created? What seems to be at stake and around which issues will critical judgements have to be made? How are the initiators situated in relation to this momentum, and how am “I” as an actor in such a process situated, in terms of role, skills, potential to exert influence and legitimacy?

On the face of it, the first judgemental step in undertaking strategy making would seem to be defining the “opportunity structure” for such an activity, and assessing whether it is likely to be “worth the effort”. In the days when spatial strategy making was conceived as a linear process, with each step following consequentially on the one before, much of the planning literature assumed not just that spatial strategy-making initiatives started with such a step, but that this step was taken by those in formal political positions, charged with the responsibility for defining public values and concerns for the wider polity (Davidoff & Reiner, 1962). “Pattern books” for decision processes and “best practice” manuals also seem to offer ways of reducing the scope for judgements that actors within strategic planning processes have to make. But the experience of practice warns against this, and intellectual resources in theory and philosophy suggest that leaning on such guides may distort the capacity for judging what is going on and what is at stake in a specific context.¹³

Experientially, those involved in strategy making in the public domain know that the “opportunity structure” is not a static phenomenon, but a complex of relations that shifts and changes through time. Nor is it something that can be easily known; instead,

knowledge about it develops through experience. An opportunity structure is not a clearly delineated and contained "action space". It grows and expands, or contracts and fades away, in part through the momentum developed as the practice itself gets underway, as transformative energy enlarges the initial "cracks" for change to allow a more substantial momentum to develop and new trajectories to be cultivated. Doubts and dilemmas are in continual play, as strategy-making practices are challenged and critiqued by those immediately involved, those potentially affected, and the wider polity. As a spatial strategy evolves, key actors in such practices may therefore find themselves "called to judgement" about whether and how to proceed at all kinds of times and institutional places. They learn from coming to understand the specificities and potentialities of the context.

Theory too has caught up with this dynamic, continually evolving quality of governance practices (Gualini, 2004; Briggs, 2008). In traditional public administration it was assumed that governance activity occurred, or should occur, according to the laws and procedures laid down by legislatures. It was expected to take place in the formal arenas specified for government activity, and to be conducted by personnel given formal positions in these procedures and arenas. Judgements were anticipated via formal processes—the council chamber vote, the appeal to law and the arbitrating judge. But judicial "balancing" in relation to formal law has difficulty when it comes to doing the integrative intellectual work which is involved in spatial strategy making. In the 1960s an alternative, supposedly more "scientific" process was proposed. This encouraged strategy makers to follow a sequential, methodological process in such "analysis", mirroring what was seen to be a "scientific method" of arriving at a strategy (Hillier & Healey, 2008). These days, a more sociological view prevails, which stresses the power of "agency" in interaction with broader forces (see Hajer & Wagenaar, 2003; Healey, 2006). This examines the way informal relations and networks create the practices through which the formal procedures are enacted. And a more political view underlines the power struggles which are played out in these practices, as actors struggle with each other, and as dynamic struggles develop between the constraints of wider forces as experienced in the specifics of a situation, and the resisting and inventive power of specific constellations of actors to challenge and change these forces (Flyvbjerg, 1998; Healey, 2007). These developments in theorising planning and policy-making activity are thus positioned in a large field of recent social scientific discussion which has been searching for productive ways of understanding the complex interactions of structuring dynamics and agency effort.¹⁴ These "in-between" contributions underline the importance of grasping the unique situatedness of particular instances of practice, rather than reading instances through the generalised lenses of procedural rules, best practice manuals, or of general structural forces. Methodologically, such a perspective underlines the value of the "thick" descriptions of "longitudinal" case studies.¹⁵

But none of this takes away the intensely political and ethical challenge of actually making judgements about spatial strategies for urban areas in the public domain. However broad the search for knowledge to ground judgements, and however shrewd and sensitive the understanding of institutional dynamics, judgements are always made in the context of limited knowledge and understanding, and of moral hazard. Though those involved may carefully aim to put prior conceptions and biases to one side, their judgements are nonetheless always shaped by implicit assumptions that somehow did not surface or were pushed aside. However hard those involved try to keep in play a rich and multi-dimensional conception of urban dynamics when shaping a strategy, their assumptions and their framing of what is at stake and what is strategic are inherently

selective simplifications. If a strategy has enduring power, it cannot avoid “reductive effects” on future ways of understanding and acting. Spatial strategy making involves exercising the power to select and simplify (Albrechts, 2004; Healey, 2007). It involves taking risks, the consequences of which can be thought about, but cannot be known (Hillier, 2008). It is this frightening prospect which so often pulls actors back to easier short-term compromises, or encourages them to hand over the judgements to someone else—another tier of government perhaps, or to the courts, and sometimes to citizens in referenda and other forms of consultation. Those who argue in a specific situation for undertaking an effort in transformative spatial strategy making need to be prepared and able to justify such a step, in terms of both why “going on as usual” will not suffice, and where momentum already exists which could be harnessed towards a new strategic orientation. They need to be able to clarify how the urban area in general could benefit, and how the “parts”—people, places and connectivities—may be affected.

Situating and Scoping

Those who take a central role in deliberate initiatives in spatial strategy making are sometimes portrayed as “authors” creating a “script” for others to enact, or as “artists” creating an idea of the future to inspire others (Beauregard, 1998). This suggests that they are somehow different from their readers and viewers, that they are producers of a strategy, not consumers. This presents such strategy makers as located in a different place from those who are to be influenced, maybe as a small and highly centralised decision-making elite governing the rest of us. Or it assumes that strategy makers can be situated as outside experts, looking in on the challenges the rest of us face as we create our urban futures. Positioning strategy makers in this way makes little sense in situations where governance activity is complexly divided up into sectors and levels of attention, diffused among diverse arenas and relations between state, economy and civil society, and continually contested. These days, those involved in spatial strategy making are more usually located within the complexities they are seeking to shape, “inside” the politics they are seeking to influence (Healey, 2007). As a former planning director has noted, “planning is a collective art . . . it is an evolving set of dreams, not one person’s dreams”.¹⁶ Viewed in this way, an initiative in spatial strategy making involves some kind of collective effort to mobilise attention to an urban area as a whole. Such initiatives are likely to be responding to matters which have created some public concern, and the work involved in them may itself reshape and generate the agendas of a polity.

Developing an idea of the “opportunity structure” for explicit spatial strategy making as discussed above is a necessary step in situating such an effort. But much more is needed to situate and scope practice adequately. One aspect of this relates to the identity of the “strategy makers”. Formally, they could be the leaders and advisers of a new political regime, as was the case in the 1970s in Portland, Oregon (Abbott, 2001) or Barcelona (Marshall, 2004). They could be consultants, hired by municipalities or some other multi-agency partnership to prepare a strategy, as has become common in the UK in recent years. They could be the strategic sections of a municipal planning department or a local elite business group.¹⁷ Whatever their starting position, the assumptions made about their institutional identity by spatial strategy makers may have a critical impact on how an initiative unfolds. Who are the “we”, as initiators? What is “our” formal legitimacy and what other kinds of legitimacy may buttress our efforts? How are “we” related to others who are promoting ideas about urban futures, or deploying resources which result in place development? What opportunities are available to us to influence events and how

could we get nearer to other important levers in the process? It is often only during the process of strategy making that those engaged in spatial strategy making become aware of the nature and potentialities of their identity. In Amsterdam, for example, the city council planners involved in metropolitan initiatives realised that they had to change the domineering image they had acquired if they were to achieve a productive collaboration with other municipalities. In the Cambridge area of the UK, the local elite lobby group involved in promoting a spatial strategy initiative had to recognise that they needed to connect to the local planning machinery in order to have influence over the power to regulate land use and development (Healey, 2007). The impact of the assumptions that people make at the start of a process affects how subsequent activities are framed. But it also influences how the initiators present themselves to others, and how this may affect the responses their work generates. A key area, then, where judgement needs to be exercised is the way in which those involved at the centre of a strategy-making initiative present their identities, both to themselves and to others, and how they keep this under review.

A second aspect relates to the position of strategy makers in a governance context. Where are they situated? Within which landscapes of power dynamics? Within which debates and arguments? Answering these questions involves making some kind of institutional audit of the agency field. Which are the key arenas where strategic ideas about place development are already evolving? How are they related to each other, and to the levers that link to key powers, such as investment resources of various kinds and the power to regulate land use and development? Such assessments might lead to judgements about who should be involved in early-stage discussions, and who should be sought out later; about which networks to work with, and when; and about the ways of establishing new networks to create more mobilisation power around a strategic initiative. The judgements made here help to build connections between ideas about critical interventions, the impacts they may have, and the actions needed to realise them.

A third aspect relates to the power of any kind of governance effort to shape ongoing place dynamics. This emphasises the importance for spatial strategy making of a rich, multi-dimensional understanding of urban development dynamics and trajectories. This means much more than just developing an evidence base, to use a term currently made fashionable in public policy in the UK (Davoudi, 2006). It involves having some understanding of the material and cultural history of an urban area, of how this shapes conceptions of what trajectories are desirable and possible, and frames what is seen to be at stake or at issue. Such understanding feeds judgements about the extent to which a strategy aims to have resonance with, and realise the potential of, emergent trajectories which can be identified as having an endogenous dynamic (locally based political energy). It also allows planners to estimate how far a particular strategy may have an intention to roll out another trajectory, derived exogenously in, around and over pre-existing cultures and practices (externally based political energy). Both possibilities involve complex assessments of the relative power of a particular strategy-making initiative in relation to ongoing urban dynamics, of the power of collective action to shape these and of the institutional dynamics of that power.

Attention to these aspects feeds judgements about what is at stake behind a particular spatial strategy-making initiative. What is at issue? For whom is it an issue? What are current conflicts and struggles about? Who are the critical "stakeholders" active now? Who else could be persuaded to become an active stakeholder? What are the critical arenas and responsibilities in the institutional terrain in which the initiative exists? How far away is the initiative from these, and what could be done (and where and when) to reduce the distances which limit influence? What might need to be done to mobilise more attention to

an initiative and to build new networks and arenas to refocus governance attention more emphatically on urban area development agendas?

Initiatives in spatial strategy making are thus “inside politics”. They also involve the exercise of the craft of “practical politics”, shaping agendas and extending influence, enhancing attention to some issues and thereby pulling attention away from others (Albrechts, 2001). All those involved in spatial strategy making that aims to shape urban development futures are therefore placed in morally complex situations. Playing the game of practical politics according to rules which focus merely on extending power and influence is hardly a sufficient basis for the craft of such a practice (Albrechts, 2003). Instead, spatial strategy making demands a good awareness of how collective action operates as a dimension of urban development dynamics. It needs a holistic or comprehensive consciousness that can focus on the way relations need to be integrated into a strategy. It also demands an expansive moral sensibility, capable of relating specific questions about who and what might gain and lose in such a process to wider issues of social and environmental well being.

It is here that all kinds of resources can help to feed the imagination of strategy makers. One is, of course, the social science literature on urban and regional dynamics, with its interweaving of research about particular phenomena and its debates about how to conceptualise the dimensions of place dynamics and how to identify particular cause-effect relations. This body of theory and research offers not foundations which can be leaned on as an alternative to first-hand thinking about a specific situation, but inspirations for enlarging the imagination which strategy makers bring to their struggle to grasp what is going on and what is at stake in a particular situation. But there are other resources too. Behind seeking out good practice examples from elsewhere, something many practitioners do, is a deeper question about “how do we go about the difficult task we face here and now?” When considering an example, practitioners want to know “how did they do it there?” Experiential accounts (autobiographies) of planners (and others) about how they went about their work are particularly valuable as aids to learning the “craft” of spatial strategy making (Forester, 1999; Kitchen, 1997; Krumholz & Forester, 1990). These accounts convey the difficulties of making situated judgements in ways that highlight how much is unknown and “at risk” in spatial strategy-making work. Such accounts emphasise the learning process through which any strategy making initiative will develop, drawing knowledge from failures as well as successes. But this consolidated resource—“book knowledge” as we might term it—is not the only source which can or should feed strategic imagination.

Enlarging Perspectives and Knowledgeability

In the past, it was often thought that the work of spatial strategy making required planning expertise in its most scientific form. The “experts”, in this conception, were those skilled in analysis and systematic research, well-informed by the scientific literature on urban and regional analysis. Yet, in the conception of spatial strategy making portrayed here, the “art” becomes a practice that does not rely too much on one particular field of systematised knowledge or area of expertise. Urban development dynamics are too complex to be grasped through work in any single discipline. Knowledge from urban and regional science, engineering, the physical and natural sciences, architecture and the humanities can provide inspirational insight. Yet many examples of the dilemmas of strategic planning in practice highlight difficulties which arise as these different fields of expertise, with their particular intellectual and practice cultures, encounter each other.

But beyond the difficulties of working across disciplinary and professional boundaries, it is important to recognise the limitations of such systematised knowledge in grasping what is going on in the particularities of a place. It is here that we find a critical resource in the experiential knowledge of those who live, work, enjoy themselves, suffer or invest in a place, those who manage it, argue about it, and get involved in collective action on its behalf; all activities that underline the particularities and specificities of a place, its qualities and meanings, and its dynamics. Critical judgements have to be made in spatial strategy-making initiatives about how to access such expertise, and how to weave this together with systematised knowledge, which itself is related in complex ways to experiential understandings (Healey, 2007). In doing so, it may not help to systematise experiences, for example through surveys about opinions and issues, as this may well smooth away the experiential depth out of which clues about what is going on and what is important may emerge. As in all planning work, spatial strategy makers need to get out and about in the streets and meeting places of their urban areas. There is no substitute for becoming "street-wise" as a way of accessing experiential knowledge, or for recognising that any place has many different streets and spaces of encounter. As Forester (1989) emphasises, the skills of noticing, listening and learning are critical to accessing this kind of experiential learning (Kitchen, 2007).

Once the value of recognising multiple sources of knowledge about places and their development is appreciated, the importance of maintaining an "open-minded" stance towards what is going on and what is at stake becomes obvious. Single-minded, one-issue agendas become difficult to justify. Instead, spatial strategy makers learn to anticipate a plurality of often overlapping and clashing agendas.¹⁸ In recognition of the complexity and diversity of concerns about urban area development that may be asserted (or that could be held if people were aware of the trajectories that might evolve from the process), open-mindedness means actively stretching out to access multiple perspectives, challenging established assumptions and cultivating debate and argument among different viewpoints (Amin *et al.*, 2000).

There are all kinds of ways of encouraging this capacity (Albrechts, 2004, 2005). Above all, it demands an expansive open-mindedness, a capacious and flexible imagination, able to recognise multiple connections between people and places through time. As Hoch suggests, it is this quality of reaching for a holistic grasp of the situation that informs the old idea of a "comprehensive" planning approach. Reality, in this model, cannot be comprehensively trapped, mapped and managed in a single model of an urban "system" (Hoch, 2007). Instead, an open-minded approach involves searching out all kinds of "systemic" qualities, that is, locating the connections through which cause-effect relations may flow to create impacts. It helps to see such systems as open and meandering threads, with evolving patterns of flow shaped by various driving forces, creating diverse patterns of nodes and networks, with fuzzy and indistinct margins rather than clear boundaries containing tightly integrated and bounded sets of relations (Churchman, 1979). Exploring such dynamics to find out what is at stake and what action possibilities exist to affect the outcome involves explorative probing as much as precisely structured inquiry, and imaginative learning as much as the production of "sound evidence".¹⁹ Approached in this way, spatial strategy making creates a "community of inquiry" around itself, which draws on and in turn helps to cultivate the overall "intelligence" of a polity (Dewey, 1991).

Many judgements are involved in developing such a "community of inquiry". What strands should be followed up first? How should the field of search be widened? How can areas of inquiry be related to each other? When and how can debate and contestation be encouraged? How can we prevent less visible strands being lost while others are

vigorously debated? An expansive, pluralistic, holistic imagination becomes a very valuable resource in making such judgements, especially if this develops within the community of inquiry. But perhaps the most critical judgement of all in relation to knowledgeability lies in making decisions about when to stop enlarging and expanding understanding, in order to get what is at stake back into focus. There can be no hard and fast rules about how to make such a judgement, no indisputable "reality checks" which can provide some external "stopping point" for probing inquiry. Instead, those centrally involved at this stage have to come to a judgement that their understanding of the context, of what is settled and what remains in doubt and contested, of what is at issue, is "enough for now". They must decide what, in the field of doubt and uncertainty, can now be put to rest, and determine in which direction the compass, which had seemed to be swinging wildly, now seems to point.²⁰ Having exercised an expansive, holistic imagination and keeping this continually in play, those making critical judgements in the public domain may find it useful to ask: in the circumstances we are in, with the resources and capacities we have, could we do more to expand our knowledge and, if we did, would this make a significant difference?²¹ This centres the quality of such strategic judgement not so much in the amount of knowledge acquired as in the range and depth of the imaginative, expansive probing which occurs. This could lead to better judgements about whether it would make much difference to "know more", and about the effort that would be needed to acquire such knowledge.

Framing Selectively

As Albrechts argues, any strategy involves a selective focus. It offers a way through the morass of issues, ideas, claims and arguments to identify one or more concepts, images and/or principles which are both meaningful and give direction. Such strategies may be arrived at by systematic search procedures, such as the construction and probing of scenarios (Albrechts, 2004, 2005). Alternatively, they may be the result of active campaigning by groups promoting particular interpretative frames, or they can be reached via an imaginative leap, or through the creative processes of collaborative encounter. However they appear, strategies come into existence through an act of recognition in which they are "summoned up", "seen", "named" and "framed" (Healey, 2007, pp. 188-189). They are "willed" into being. They make sense because they show how specific problems, issues and concerns can be addressed more effectively when located in a wider frame.

A spatial strategy for an urban area, in this view, combines a holistic sensibility about urban development dynamics with a politically-shrewd awareness about what is critically at issue and what could be done. It involves judgements about how far it is possible to shape these dynamics in a transformative way, and highlights which specific actions (taken now, or in a future where the parameters of action possibilities can be foreseen with some confidence) have the potential to make a real difference to what is at issue. It involves judgements about what to position "frontstage" when it comes to action, and what to leave "backstage" for the time being (Giddens, 1984; Healey, 2007). The heart of a strategy, therefore, lies in the way that it frames ideas.

Creating the frame and identifying critical actions are both acts of intense simplification and selectivity. They are thus acutely political, since simplification inherently involves reductive discrimination (see above). However hard a strategy-making initiative attempts to keep multiple dimensions and perspectives "in play", some inevitably become the dominant focus as strategy making proceeds. This focus, in turn, evolves into the framework through which other understandings are attached and interpreted. Framing helps to reduce

uncertainties, and to allow people to see and justify action possibilities. Because strategies simplify how urban development dynamics are understood and how possible future directions are identified, those who initiate spatial strategy-making efforts carry a burden of moral responsibility.²² They need to make complex and challenging judgements that go beyond whether it is possible to inject a strategic orientation into a particular governance landscape: they must also keep in view the potential consequences of consolidating governance activity around a strategic direction at a particular moment in time.

However, as stressed earlier, spatial strategy-making processes rarely proceed in a linear way. Creating a strategic framing concept is a process which evolves interactively with the work of situating and scoping, and of developing knowledgeability. Sometimes a clear strategic frame dominates a strategy-making process from the start. Sometimes it only appears after action possibilities have emerged from scoping and probing work, allowing it to be seen as a background to the identification of specific projects and proposals. Alternatively, it may come into being during an imaginative leap, as a new possibility comes into view. However it is discovered, framing, as Schon and Rein (1994) insist, is an integrative, creative process. Strategic frames cannot be arrived at by an analytic procedure, by aggregating up from "parts to wholes", as some imagined during the strategic planning movement of the 1960s (Mintzberg, 1994). Nevertheless, strategy making involves thinking systemically, by which I mean that it focuses on systems of relationships, such as those connecting where we live and work, or those surrounding the dynamic relations of housing markets, or those connecting how we live and our environmental impacts.

However, an over-reliance on previously developed models of urban systems leads to reductive simplification, which may bear little relationship to, and have little resonance with, the complex dynamics and specificities of what is happening in a particular place and time (Churchman, 1979; Verma, 1998). Planning literature has long recognised this, yet remains full of proposals for idealised urban forms or models of urban systems, all of which appear to offer a ready-made, integrated image of a whole system.²³ The alternative to this is to develop strategic frames which embody a sensitivity to the complexity, plurality and indeterminacy of particular urban development dynamics as they emerge, and which generate sufficient energy to inspire and direct transformative actions within those dynamics with the aim of shaping what happens in a place. This inspiring and directing quality lies as much in the frame as in the selective specification of actions. The frame allows those involved in shaping their own actions to position their activities in a wider context, and to develop a way of thinking and valuing which inspires and justifies what they do. The strategic frame, if widely referred to, then becomes a piece of public infrastructure, part of the capacity of a particular political community.

It is sometimes argued that strategic frames that have significant effects can only be created through a process that allows a single designer or design group to create a synthesis from their efforts in scoping and probing. This may take the form of an image, or a spatial sketch, or a verbal statement about direction and qualities. Behind this approach lies the idea that strategic design can only be an individual process. Yet studies of strategy making suggest that creating frames is as much a social as an individual process (Vickers, 1965). It involves making syntheses, and demands systemic thinking rather than analytic thinking. This can happen in collective contexts as well as in individual brains. Some fear that such collective processes can only arrive at lowest common denominator compromises. This fear assumes that participants engage in a zero-sum game, playing out their conflicts of interest. It ignores the creative social learning that can occur in processes where probing inquiry and exploratory framing occur.

Strategic frames do not appear fully formed. Frames arise through processes of collective "sense making" (Forester, 1989), as those involved seek out some kind of coherence among the issues and understandings as they become aware of them. Frames may already be lying around in an early state of conception, or in debates surrounding communities of inquiry, waiting to be summoned up and receive explicit attention.²⁴ In situations where understandings have been very diffuse and fragmented, such meaning making often gets explored not just through defining alternative designs and options, but by the use of metaphor and analogy ("What is our situation similar to?" "What if we think like this?", "Let us suppose this is the case?") (Verma, 1998; Weston, 1996). Framing work, like the process of probing the available knowledge about situations and issues, requires an expansive yet integrative, pluralistic yet synthetic, collective imagination. Pursued in this way, efforts at probing and developing strategic frames have the effect of making participants transform the way they think about their particular interests and trajectories (Innes & Booher, 1999, 2003).²⁵ Strategic frames which have transformative power achieve this potential in part by changing how key actors think.²⁶

Because frames that transform are so powerful, making strategic judgements about them is perhaps the most ethically challenging task in spatial strategy making. Dominant framing ideas have a tendency to emerge as a process proceeds, though this can create problems: sometimes one assertive voice may impose a frame which seems superficially adequate to all involved in the process, yet lacks adequate probing, with the result that issues that later turn out to be highly significant get relegated to the "back stage" of attention. It is for this reason that deciding whether to employ a strategic frame becomes such a key judgement. In some situations it may be enough to focus on a few key actions, since it may be too difficult (intellectually or politically) to provide an explicit justification for them even though the compass seems to point quite clearly in their direction. It is only later on that the strategic frame which lies behind the actions can perhaps be articulated. Alternatively, a key strategic action may unsettle established frames, creating doubt, and thus allowing new ideas and actions to emerge. In these cases it may not be helpful to spend much time producing an inspiring vision. But in other cases, a clear strategic frame may be exactly what is needed to help people move on and to reduce the incapacity which often accompanies doubts and uncertainties. In these scenarios, it matters a great deal that a frame is produced. The precise moment of the strategy-making process when it is summoned up is also significant, as is the issue of its contents and dimensions.

Arriving at a strategic frame, which many see as the key product of a spatial strategy-making process, is thus an intellectually challenging, politically risky and morally demanding task. Yet participants and those who have set up the process are likely to expect some kind of vision statement or an outline of an overall strategy, especially where the strategy-making process was designed to resolve doubts and allow people to find a way forward into the future. Those charged with the task of articulating the "strategy" may find it helpful to go back to the scoping issues, and ask again what specific governance work a particular strategic frame will perform, in the context in which it now sits. Will it inspire, justify or mobilise people? Will it focus significant attention on the problems, and thus have an effect on both subsequent governance action and urban and regional dynamics? And are these effects all desirable? Further, what is the implication of our thinking about these questions for the way a strategy is expressed, both in terms of its framing conception and its specific actions? What are the relative merits of a visual sketch, a policy statement, a policy argument, a narrative, an artistic image, an imaginative story, a geographical map or a computer game in conveying the meaning and implications of the frame and the selected actions proposed?

Above all, articulating a strategic frame for the spatial development of an urban area demands a synthetic imagination, which recognises that wholes and parts do not relate to each other mechanically but are instead design ideas, with each inspiring the other through relational resonance rather than specified links. Strategy making demands both the ability to see a whole reflected in a part, and the capacity to recognise in the whole the possibility of parts (Churchman, 1979). Because such syntheses are contestable simplifications that are nonetheless intended to do actual governance work, strategy making in the public domain demands a moral sensibility as well as an imaginative capacity. It requires an ethical awareness not just of what is promoted but of what is left out, what is pushed to the background, as the selected frame and actions are forced into the limelight. In other words, spatial strategy making demands the courage to step forward, combined with the ability to recognise the provisionality and revisability of both framing conceptions and actions, and of the underlying assumptions on which these are based. Some individuals may have a cast of mind which tends towards this combination of synthetic imagination and ethical reflexivity, and such people often come to be acknowledged as great planners. But these qualities can also be encouraged in a polity. Spatial strategy-making work thus both benefits from, and helps to cultivate, a political culture which can relate specific issues and interventions to wider qualities of the collective experience of living in urban areas.²⁷

Conclusions

All planning work involves some ability to set specific actions in wider contexts. This, in turn, involves making explicit connections between current action options and their potential impacts on people and places in the future, in this place and elsewhere (Kitchen, 2007; Hoch, 2007). Planners need to maintain a broad awareness of the multiple dimensions of such wider relations, as these impact on the specifics of the issues at hand. Following Hoch, I have termed this a holistic or comprehensive sensibility, a faculty capable of grasping the broader context of a problem whilst selecting specific aspects and actions to guide current action. If we accept the justification for planning as an activity that seeks to improve social and environmental wellbeing in a world of diverse peoples who interconnect in complex ways with place, then such a consciousness needs to be infused with the ability to sustain open-minded and pluralistic views, while recognising the moral imperatives to pursue actions that promote just and sustainable outcomes.

In this paper, I have tried to show that engaging in spatial strategy making for urban areas is a particularly demanding field of planning work. The challenge, though, is not one of analytical capability, as theorists of the mid twentieth century argued. Nor is it one of design imagination, as the town and landscape designers who dominated planning in the early twentieth century suggested. Though both of these capabilities are useful, at the heart of skilful strategy making of the kind that has the potential to enhance the future possibilities of an urban area, are four skills. Firstly, spatial strategy making requires a capacity to know a place in all its complexities, in its collective expressions and relations, and in the fine grain of its social, environmental, political and physical fabric. Secondly, it needs an imaginative capacity to see opportunities now which can provide the momentum for future development and safeguard against the many challenges to well-being that emerge in contemporary urban life. Thirdly, it necessitates the intellectual and political courage to engage in synthetic thinking, drawing together understandings and insights to imagine future trajectories and select specific pathways. Above all, though, spatial strategy making demands a capacity for judgement which is

situated within, and sensitive to, the contingencies of particular times and places, rather than drawing on generalised theories of urban change or accepted methodological protocols.²⁸

Spatial strategy-making efforts which have transformative and structuring effects on future directions achieve this by becoming a part of the institutional infrastructure of a community. They act through their role as a reference frame for those with the resources to deploy, and over time they come to shape urban futures. However, they are neither a blueprint for building the future, nor a generalised dream about a utopia to come. Rather, they reflect a process of trying to tie together elements of the building and dreaming that constitute part of the ongoing life of a polity. In Table 1, I attempt to distinguish such transformative strategy-making efforts from the kind of routine “strategy production”, which merely responds to some external demand for an urban plan, without any connection to local momentum which could turn such an exercise into a transformative frame to shape future directions. However, there is no sharp divide between the two: routine strategy production may merely follow some procedural rule book or best practice exemplar to meet compliance requirements, but it can have the modest ambition of articulating what the policy actually does, reflecting the overall direction that emerges from the individual actions of those on the ground.²⁹ Such an exercise may help to decide whether or not there are issues that need more fundamental attention, and, if so, may act as a starting point for a more transformative effort in spatial strategy making.

However, embarking on the type of spatial strategy making that makes a difference is no easy enterprise. It is both an art and a craft. It has elements of both scientific analysis and of design science, but also involves a sensibility that is not cultivated in either. Spatial strategy making, situated in the public domain and concerned for urban futures, demands a more historical, anthropological and geographical imagination, capable of grasping the relations between people and place through time. Rather than procedural pattern books, strategy makers are perhaps better advised to read accounts, histories and biographies of those involved in spatial strategy making, to enhance the antennae with which they learn about the specific challenges they face.³⁰ Spatial strategy making can make a material contribution to the social and environmental well being of many in an urban area, if approached with a political, economic and cultural imagination that can grasp the relation between people and the governance of place, and understand the formation of publics and

Table 1. Transformative versus responsive strategy making

Dimension of strategy making	Transformative strategy making	Responsive strategy making
Mobilise attention	Re-orientate attention to issues which lie behind immediate agendas, where this would highlight neglected opportunities and challenges	Express what the current aims, values and directions of our agency seem to be, with respect to shaping urban futures
Scope the situation	Identify where the energy for change may lie and build coalitions for change which expand this energy	Identify what our agency can achieve
Enlarge intelligence	Explore and recast agendas of problems, issues and potential actions and stakes, through accessing multiple sources of knowledge	Summarise what we seem to know
Create frames and select actions	Articulate strategic ideas within which specific issues and actions can be prioritised and given some justification and coherence	Find a way to give some kind of explicit expression and coherence to the above

the qualities of a polity. Further, such strategy making may create an infrastructure for discussion, generating a public realm asset within which the difficult material and moral challenges faced by those planning urban areas can be debated as the future unfolds. If developed with knowledgeability, imaginative skill, courage and ethical sensibility, spatial strategy-making efforts with transformative ambitions have significant potential to contribute by enhancing the intelligence and capacity of a polity, and thus improve the future well being of urban citizens and stakeholders (Dewey, 1991).

Notes

1. This paper is a development of a version produced for the *Liber Amicorum* prepared to celebrate the retirement of Professor Louis Albrechts at the Universiteit Leuven (Van den Broeck & Moulaert, 2008). I would like to thank the Editor, Heather Campbell and four anonymous referees for helpful and insightful comments on an earlier version of this paper.
2. See Albrechts *et al.* (2001, 2003), Fedeli and Gastaldi (2004), Marshall (2004), Motte (2007), Salet and Faludi (2000), Salet *et al.* (2003).
3. Ward (2002) notes that it was common in the interwar years for a strategy to be known by the name of the planner who led the planning team. These days, it is more common for a strategy to be known by its place name.
4. For the empirical basis of my reflections, see Healey *et al.* (1997), Vigar *et al.* (2000), Healey (2007). I have also benefited greatly from discussions with skilled strategic planners over the years, and learned from my own experience as a "strategic manager".
5. The term "governance" is used in several ways in planning literature. For some, it implies a shift from undertaking collective action primarily through the institutions of formal government and resort to all kinds of other coalitions, alliances and "partnerships". My usage is as in the text above.
6. Note that my use of "strategy" here is not related to the Habermasian distinction between strategic and communicative "rationality" (Habermas, 1984). A strategy in the sense that I use it here could arise through the exercise of both rationalities, or some hybrid between them.
7. By the term "polity", I mean a governance "culture" in the sense of the qualities of the political life of some collectivity with a political identity.
8. These "orientations" are given different terms in the planning literature. The most common term, taken from the work of Schon and Rein (1994), is a "frame", or framing set of ideas. This gets linked to the idea of a "discourse" as used in work on struggles between alternative orientations and in the capacity to transform them as developed in interpretive policy analysis, drawn from Foucauldian inspiration (see Hajer, 1995). Faludi uses the term "doctrine", although he developed this to describe a very strongly developed conception of the Dutch landscape (Faludi & van der Valk, 1994).
9. See Esping Anderson, 1990; Gualini, 2004, 2006; Jessop, 2002; Le Gales, 2002.
10. This has always been a challenge for those promoting a perspective on urban dynamics which pays attention to the interplay of programmes and projects across an urban area. See studies in planning history, notably Ward (2002), Nasr and Volait (2003).
11. I think, therefore, that the difference between my understanding of strategy and that argued recently by Newman (2008) is very small.
12. Cities which have attracted funding from various national and EU programmes are particularly prone to such experiences.
13. There is a long tradition in planning thought which emphasises the importance of creatively responding to specific situations in experimental and exploratory ways, rather than relying on prior models and templates, see Lindblom (1990), Schon (1983), Forester (1989, 1999).
14. See Giddensian structuration theory, actor-network concepts, the varieties of institutionalist understanding. In philosophy also, the rediscovery of the USA pragmatic tradition, and also the lessons from European phenomenology and post-structuralist philosophy, underline the importance of situated practical judgement within social processes.
15. See Flyvbjerg (2001) and Yanow and Schwartz-Shea (2006) on case study method.
16. Talk by Larry Beasley, UBC, Vancouver, 9 June 2007.
17. See, for example, the cases of Amsterdam and the Cambridge sub-region in Healey (2007), and Salt Lake City in Briggs (2008). For the role of consultants see Healey (2008).

18. Here I draw on arguments which promote the positive benefits of discordant, conflicting viewpoints in resisting tendencies to univocal, monist policy discourses (see, for example, Connolly, 1987, 2005). The pluralism implied here is about a plurality of values and perspectives, not just a plurality of interests.
19. See Lindblom (1990), Healey (2007), see also Hillier (2007) for a similar conclusion arrived at through engaging with the poststructuralist theorists of complexity.
20. This image of a "compass" derives from the USA pragmatist writers (see Healey, 2009).
21. This draws on central arguments in the pragmatist tradition, see Thayer (1982).
22. See Campbell (2006) for a discussion of how general values, such as a concern for justice, are enacted in the making of practical judgements in the planning field.
23. See, for example, the new urbanism ideas (Grant, 2006), and the various ecologically inspired utopias that have appeared in recent years.
24. See Dewey (1982) for a very interesting discussion of these processes in an essay on the pattern of inquiry.
25. See James's idea of how we "heave" our will towards a new direction, cutting off another as we do so (in Thayer, 1982, pp. 184–185).
26. See Hajer (1995) on the re-framing that happens in the transformation of policy discourses.
27. See Healey (2004b), Briggs (2008).
28. Skilled practitioners have long known the reality of such contingencies. Social scientists are now giving these much more attention (Jessop, 2002; Sørensen & Torfing, 2007; Westbrook, 2005).
29. See Barrett and Fudge (1981) for a discussion of the interactive relation between policy and action, which argues that policies are often made as a consolidation of what is reflected in the flow of action.
30. See, for example, the classic case histories (Altshuler 1965; Meyerson & Banfield, 1955), and more recently also Flyvbjerg (1998). Other accounts by strategic planners include Albrechts (2001), Goodstadt and Buchan (2002), Krumholz and Forester (1990), Wannop (1985), while there are an increasing number of "longitudinal" accounts of urban development and planning experiences in individual cities (for example, Fainstein, 2001; Madanipour, 1998; Abbott, 2001; Punter, 2003; Hooper & Punter, 2006; Healey, 2007; Angotti, 2008; Briggs, 2008).

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